Recursive Embedding in Literature

Jay Ser

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Questions to Keep in Mind

- Is everything syntax?
- “Rapid fading" design feature of language (Hockett)
- Consider an arbitrary ABBA structure in literature. Is there a dependency between **(a)** the corresponding opening and closing letters and **(b)** the embedded inner structure and the framing outer structure?

In discourse (Legate):

A: Do you carry Michelob?

B: [*sees A has a wet umbrella*] Is it still raining?

A: Yes, unfortunately.

B: It's over there, near the plastic cups.

In human activity (Pulvermiller, Moro):

open the door

open the bottle

close the bottle

close the door

Ring Composition

Diagram 1

The men pass swiftly over the plain
- The earth groans beneath them
  - The name Typhoeus appears
    - ZEUS LASHES THE EARTH IN ARIMA
  - The name Typhoeus appears
- The earth groans beneath them

The men pass swiftly over the plain.

Figure: Sentential(?) ring composition in the Iliad (Niles)

So the men went, as if the whole earth were being consumed by fire; and the earth groaned beneath them, as when Zeus the Thunderer lashes the earth about Typhoeus in anger, in Arima, where Typhoeus is said to lie — so greatly did the earth groan beneath the feet of the men as they walked, and swiftly they passed over the plain.

Ring Composition: *Beowulf*

Þæm eafera wæs æfter cenned
geong in geardum þone God sende
folce to frofre; fyrenðearfe ongeat
þe hie ær drugon aldorlease
lange hwile; him þæs Liffrea,
wuldres Wealdend woroldare forgeaf,
Beowulf wæs breme —blæd wide sprang—
Scyldes eafera Scedelandum in.

To him in time a son was born,
young in the land, whom God sent
as a comfort to the people; He understood the dire need
they had suffered earlier, lacking a king
for a long time. Therefore the Lord of life,
Ruler of glory, granted them worldly grace.
Beowulf was famous, his name rang widely,
Scyld's son, in the lands of the North.

(ll. 12–19)[4]

"... the poet uses ring composition as a means of traveling from the immediate reality... to an 'other,' legendary reality, which is used as a point of comparison..., then back again to the present.
"Just as the monster Typhoeus is 'chained' between balanced links of transitional verse, the Danes's previous sufferings are enclosed safely within the envelope of God's mercy" (Niles).

Ring Composition: *Beowulf*

Diagram 2

- "To him a son"
  - Phrase describing Beowulf: "young in the land"
    - God sending a blessing to the people
      - THE DANES'S LONG YEARS OF MISFORTUNE
    - God sending a blessing to the people
  - Phrase describing Beowulf: "famous"
- "Scyld's son."

Diagram 3

- Preliminaries
  - Grendel approaching
  - Grendel rejoicing
  - Grendel devouring Handscioh
- Grendel's wish to flee; "fingers cracked"
  - Uproar in hall; Danes stricken with terror
    - HEOROT IN DANGER OF FALLING
  - Uproar in hall; Danes stricken with terror
- "Joints burst"; Grendel forced to flee
- Aftermath
  - Grendel slinking back toward fens
  - Beowulf rejoicing
  - Beowulf left with Grendel's arm.

Ring Composition: *Beowulf*

Diagram 4

- Night: attack by Grendel's dam
  - Dawn: men leaving their chambers
    - Speeches
      - Hrothgar to Beowulf
      - Beowulf to Hrothgar
    - Departure from Heorot in a troop
      - Journey to pool
        - landscape: "unknown path"
        - detail: Æschere's head
      - Pool welling with Æschere's blood
        - Arming of Beowulf
          - Farewell to Hrothgar
            - Descent through infested waters
              - FIGHT IN DEPTHS OF POOL
            - Ascent through cleansed waters
          - Greeting by Geats
        - Disarming of Beowulf
      - Pool welling with Grendel's blood
      - Journey from pool
        - landscape: "known ways"
        - detail: Grendel's head
    - Arrival at Heorot in a troop
    - Speeches
      - Beowulf to Hrothgar
      - Hrothgar to Beowulf
  - Sunset: men returning to chambers
- Night: uneventful.

Diagram 5

- Rifling of barrow by unnamed Geat
  - The hoard
    - description of contents
    - "lay of the last survivor"
  - Dragon's night attack; Beowulf's response
  - Journey to barrow by thirteen Geats
    - Long speech by Beowulf: Swedish-Geatish hostility (ll. 2425–509)
      - Short heroic speech of Beowulf (ll. 2510–37)
        - Beowulf's approach to the barrow
          - SLAYING OF DRAGON; BEOWULF'S DEATH
        - Geats' approach to the barrow
      - Short heroic speech of Wiglaf (ll. 2862–91)
    - "Messenger's prophecy": Swedish-Geatish hostility (ll. 2900–3027)
  - Journey to barrow by main body of Geats
  - The hoard
    - description of contents
    - speech of Wiglaf, a last survivor
- Rifling of barrow by eight Geats.

Ring Composition: *Beowulf*

Diagram 6

- Prologue
  - A. Panegyric for Scyld
  - B. Scyld's funeral
  - C. History of Danes before Hrothgar
  - D. Hrothgar's order to build Heorot
- First fight
  - Grendel's unexpected night attack
  - Sea voyage to Denmark
  - Greeting by hosts
    - Hrothgar
    - Unferth
    - Wealhtheow
  - *Fight with Grendel* (see Diagram 3)
- Interlude (Great banquet, nightfall)
  - Second fight
    - Grendel's dam's unexpected night attack
    - *Fight with Grendel's Dam* (see Diagram 4)
- Interlude
  - Banquet, nightfall
  - Farewell to hosts
  - Sea voyage home
  - Reception in Geatland
- Third fight
  - Dragon's unexpected night attack
  - *Fight with Dragon* (see Diagram 5)
- Epilogue
  - D. Beowulf's order to build his barrow
  - C. History of Geats after Beowulf ("messenger's prophecy")
  - B. Beowulf's funeral
  - A. Eulogy for Beowulf.

"In a way too consistent to be the result of chance, events in the poems' gradual unfolding find a reply in events from the poem's gradual close. While these events are like one another in some ways, they are antithetical in others...

"In *Beowulf*, it would appear, human success is and human failure are conceived as an inseperable pair...

Ring Composition: *Beowulf*

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"The poet, in fact, relied so heavily on this sort of patterning that for him balance and symmetry of thought must have been second nature" (Niles).

Criticism of Ring Composition Literature (Dane)

- “Neither the general nor the geometric form of ring composition can lead to convincing conclusion abouts about compositional practices beyond those that could be derived from the simple existence of specific repetitions."
  - e.g., Niles identifies an embedded theme as “Grendel approaching" or “phrase describing Beowulf."
    “Such a ring surely owes its existence to critical rather than poetic viruosity" (Dane).
- “The entire notion of a frame is trivial and tautological: some sort of frame is logically implied in the very definition of a digression"
- “The definition of the supposed phenomenon will in and of itself produce only positive evidence of the phenomenon."
  i.e., a constant or random sequence of motifs only provide *neutral* evidence

Epic Frame Story: *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

Introduction to *Ādiparvan*:

- "This elaborate embedded tale of Cyavana, where one level of the story is interrupted to insert subordinate episodes, is evidently the result of lengthy historical growth"
- The first book of the *Mahābhārata*, a Sanskrit Epic about "the passing of of the heroic age and the obliteration of the warrior race." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mahabharata
- Primarily narrated by Vaiśampāyana to king Janamejaya during the *sarpasattra* ritual
  - During intervals of recess during the ritual, Vaiśampāyana tells Janamejaya about the history of the Bhārata

Epic Frame Story: *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

"The choice of the sarpasattra as the setting for the frame story of the Mahdbhdrata is a felicitous one for three reasons. First, the theme of the destruction of the snakes, which is interrupted in time to save Taksaka, prefigures the fundamental theme of the epic it introduces – the passing of the heroic age and the obliteration of the warrior race. Indeed, it is the unborn Pariksit, saved by the special intervention of Krsna, who is the sole survivor of the epic era in the present age. That Pariksit's killer, Taksaka, should be the one snake saved by special intervention from the flames of Janamejaya's sattra makes the two apocalyptic stories interlock" (Minkowski).

But this "interlock[ing]" relationship between *sarpasattra* and the main contents of *Mahābhārata* is a deliberate narrative device

Epic Frame Story: *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

"The Mahabhdrata... provides itself with a sensible, well-structured frame story – a long programmatic ritual session with regular intervals in the action set aside for talk, and a session, furthermore, that interlocks thematically with the epic it introduces" (Minkowski).

The interlocking nature of the narrative induces embedded storytelling.

Epic Frame Story: *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

"If Vaiśampāyana is telling us the story of the Bhāratas, then who is telling us about Vaiśampāyana?"

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The *Mahābhārata* describes the "history of its own narration" by adding a second narration that tells of the first :)
The outer story is also narrated during a ritual.

Epic Frame Story: *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

"The sages' motivation in requesting the Bharata story is made evident. The Bhārata story is the equal of the Vedas; it is a Samhita composed by Vyasa. Their interest, unlike Janamejaya's, is based on the ontological status of the epic, and not on the content of its main story" (Minkowski).

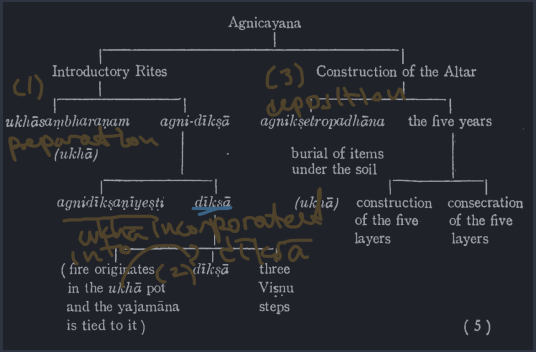
i.e., there is no need for another outer layer of narration

Embedding Structure in *Mahābhārata* and *Ādiparvan*

- "The embedded story must start after the story which embeds it. One cannot append a substory at the beginning or end, outside its frame."
- 'Linking passages' are highly formulaic:
  - Audience established $\Longrightarrow$ narrator enters $\Longrightarrow$ hospitality $\Longrightarrow$ question to the narrator $\Longrightarrow$ request for more
  - The lexical and morphosyntax used during these transitions are predictable

Ritual and Epics

- Rituals often have recesses during which epics are told
- Embedding structure in ritual:



sāmidhenis
āghāras
prayājas
ājyabhāgas
pradhāna 1
upāṃśuyāga
pradhāna 2
sviṣṭakṛt
anuyājas
sūktavāka
śamyuvāka